

Pahankanuwa Sermon #10

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

*Vācānurakkhī manasā susaṃvuto, kāyena ca akusalaṃ na kayirā;
Ete tayo kammapathe visodhaye, ārādhaye maggaṃ isippaveditaṃ.*

From:

Verse 281 from the Maggavagga (Chapter on the Path) of the Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

This Duruthu Poya day is significant to us Buddhists because of a historical event—namely, the visit of our Leader of Peace, the Teacher of the Three Worlds, the Buddha, to Kelaniya. However, for many who think and contemplate according to the conventional calendar of the world, this Duruthu Poya in particular may also be significant as the first Poya day of a new year—and a new century.

Like in this country, many in the world look at this calendar, look at the numbers on the calendar, and anticipate a new era—a new dawn. Expecting a new dawn through the calendar itself, without any regard for one's philosophy of life, and without making an effort to rectify the shortcomings of one's philosophy of life, is a great delusion. Indeed, if one expects a new dawn, a new era in one's life, one must examine one's philosophy of life, steer away from the path of decline, and enter the Path of Dhamma (*dhamma-magga*) trodden by the Buddhas, Paccekabuddhas, and Great Arahants. One must step into it. The verse we have chosen as our theme today is one that presents that Path of Dhamma in an extremely concise and simple manner. What is also evident from the background story of this verse is the fate that befell a monk who set out on an unrighteous path (*adhamma-magga*) in expectation of a new dawn—a new era.

At one time, while the Buddha was residing at the Veluvana Monastery in Rājagaha, one day the highly faithful Great Arahant Moggallāna and Venerable Lakkhaṇa were descending from the Gijjhakūṭa (Vulture's Peak) mountain. At one point, the Great Arahant Moggallāna smiled slightly. Seeing this, Venerable Lakkhaṇa asked for the reason. The Great Arahant Moggallāna said, "Friend, I will not speak of this matter here. Ask me in the presence of the Buddha."

So, both of these elders, after collecting alms in the city of Rājagaha, approached the Buddha. Having arrived at the Veluvana Monastery, Venerable Lakkhaṇa then asked in the presence of the Buddha, "Why, friend, did you smile in that manner?" At that moment, the Great Arahant Moggallāna declared: "At that moment, I saw a certain massive *preta* (hungry ghost) form. The body was like that of a human, but the head was like that of a pig. Close to it, there was a pig's tail in its mouth. Worms were oozing from its mouth. Seeing this, a thought arose in me: 'What an extraordinarily strange form! I have never seen such a form before.'" Hearing this, the Buddha expressed his approval: "It is clear that my disciples live with eyes that see. I, too, saw this creature. I saw this creature at the very moment I attained Buddhahood at the foot of the Bodhi tree. However, I did not declare it until now because, if many did not believe what I said and thought it to be a lie, they might bind themselves to unwholesome deeds (*akusala*) and be reborn in hell. Now that Moggallāna has spoken of this matter as a witness, I also endorse it. What Moggallāna said is true."

Then, on that occasion, the Sangha asked: "Blessed One, what was the past unwholesome deed (*akusala*) committed by this person to receive such a *preta* rebirth?" It was on this occasion that the Buddha brought forth the past account.

During the time of Kassapa Buddha—when speaking of the time of Kassapa Buddha, these devotees must bear in mind that the maximum lifespan of humans was twenty-thousand years. It is worth keeping this in mind first. It is mentioned in this Dhamma. Lifespans as long as twenty-thousand years. Not only that, during the times of other Buddhas, lifespans were forty-thousand, sixty-thousand, eighty-thousand years, and even longer periods. Thinking about this, these devotees can now realize: we—who jump up and down, dance, and enjoy ourselves because a century has passed—when we think about the lifespans of those long-lived humans, aren't our lives like those of ephemerals? Well, anyway, the Buddha now directs the minds of the Sangha to the time of Kassapa Buddha. At that time, two monks of the Sangha lived together in great harmony in a village monastery. The senior monk had sixty Rains Retreats (*vassa*) since his higher ordination (*upasampadā*). The second monk had fifty-nine Rains Retreats. Although there was a difference of one year, that second monk was

extremely humble, carrying the bowl and robes of the senior monk like a novice monk (*sāmaṇera*). He performed all the duties and services. Like two children of the same mother—like two born of the same womb—they spent their time in great harmony.

While they were living in this manner, a Dhamma-preaching (*dhamma-kathika*) monk arrived at that place. It was a day for listening to the Dhamma. Since these monks were accustomed to listening to the Dhamma on such days, they invited this Dhamma-preaching monk to deliver some Dhamma. When he preached the Dhamma, these two monks expressed great joy.

The next day, they went to the village for alms together with this monk. After the alms-round, the senior monk invited this Dhamma-preaching monk to preach the Dhamma to the laypeople. When he preached the Dhamma, the people were highly pleased and invited him for the next day as well. In this way, this monk became very popular. He went on alms-round to the surrounding villages together with those two monks.

Meanwhile, a thought occurred to this monk—a sinful, evil thought: "Alas! These are two weak monks, two foolish monks. I must see to it that I drive these two away from here and take over this place." Thinking thus, he devised a scheme. What was the scheme? Going to the senior monk—the elder monk—one day, pretending to share a great secret out of friendship, he said, "Venerable sir, I have one thing to tell you." When asked, "What is it? Tell me, tell me," he sighed heavily and said, "Alas! Speaking of this matter might cause great harm," and left it at that. He did not say it. Likewise, he went to the second monk and started by saying, "I have something to tell you," and then withdrew without saying it.

Was the second monk highly trustful? "Alas, yes! We are very harmonious, like children born of the same womb. I have not seen any fault in that venerable one all this time," he declared. "If that is so, venerable sir, from the day I arrived, that monk has been saying to associate with the senior monk with caution, to be careful." Then, that senior monk developed great anger towards the second monk. A hatred (*dosa*) arose, thinking, "Alas, did he say such a thing to a visiting monk?" Next, going to the second monk as well, that monk told a similar slanderous tale. "It wasn't even slander—it was an outright lie." When he said it, that monk too was estranged; they were split apart.

These two, who used to go on alms-round together in harmony, went on alms-round separately the next day. After the alms-round, the second monk arrived at the alms-hall first. Seeing the senior monk coming, he thought whether to go forward to take his bowl and robes as was his usual habit. Thinking, "No matter, let me perform the duty that is mine," he went forward. As he approached, the

senior monk drove him away, saying, "Undisciplined monk, you are not worthy of holding my bowl and robes." Then, both of them spoke out: "Do you think I am holding on to this monastery?" The senior monk also spoke in that manner—one can imagine what kind of dispute it was. Having disputed in this manner, what was the result? These two—one went out through the front door, and the other went out through the back door. They departed. Then, that cunning Dhamma-preacher monk came forward pretendingly, saying, "No, no, do not go, do not go!" acting as if to settle the matter. When those monks said, "You may stay here," he remained there.

The next day, when that Dhamma-preacher monk went to the village for alms, the people asked, "Where are our two monks?" When he replied, "Those two clan-monks of yours quarreled and disputed, and have departed," the foolish people also thought this to be true. The wise ones, however, realized:

"Undoubtedly, it is this monk who must have arranged matters for those two to depart." In any case, those two monks went separately to distant areas. Because of this matter, the hatred (*dosa*) and other defilements (*kilesa*) that arose in their minds were so intense that they could not concentrate their minds. They could not meditate. In this way, a long period of time passed.

When we say "a long period of time," what is the event described next? The Buddha declares that after 100 years—and "one hundred years" must be understood in relation to the twenty-thousand-year lifespan—after one hundred years, by chance, both of these monks arrived as guests at a certain hermitage (*senāsana*) in a distant province. At that place, the Sangha offered the exact same hermitage to both of these monks. So, first, the elder monk arrived and just as he sat on the bed in the lodging, the second monk also arrived. This was an event like a strange, wondrous convergence. Then, just as he entered, recognizing him, tears began to flow from the eyes of this senior monk. With great sorrow, his eyes filled with tears, thinking whether to speak or not, the second monk asked, "Venerable sir, during all the time I associated with you, did you see any fault in me, in body or speech?" "No, no, I saw no such thing." "Then why did you say such a thing to that newly arrived monk, telling him not to trust me?" "Alas, I said no such thing!" "I too was told such a thing about you."

Then they realized that it was because of the words of that cunning monk that they had been estranged. Immediately, both of them reconciled after confessing their offenses (*āpatti-desanā*). Then they talked to each other: "We must now go to search for that cunning monk." Having traveled there, when they approached that monastery, the Dhamma-preacher monk, seeing them coming, came forward to take their bowls and robes. This senior monk, then—perhaps due to the majesty of the Dhamma (*dhamma-teja*)—snapped his fingers and

said, "People like you do not deserve to stay here," speaking words of banishment. Unable to bear it, that monk left, abandoning that place. That was the event.

In connection with that, the Buddha then declares: due to that grave unwholesome deed (*akusala*) committed by that Dhamma-preacher monk, for a long period—for an entire interval between two Buddhas (*buddhāntara*), from the time of Kassapa Buddha to this Buddha-era—he boiled in the Avīci hell. As the residual result (*vipāka*) of that bad karma (*kamma*)—as the tail-end or the conclusion of that sinful deed—he has now received this *preta* existence (*preta-ātma-bhāva*). This is the event.

Having declared so, and explaining that this is the consequence of being unrestrained in mind, body, and speech and converting them to evil in this manner—that this is the state of affairs—using that event as a background and foundation, the Buddha, as an instruction to the world, uttered that verse of Dhamma (*dhamma-gāthā*) which we mentioned earlier:

Vācānurakkhī manasā susaṁvuto

Kāyena ca akusalaṁ na kayirā

Ete tayo kammapathe visodhaye

Ārādhaye maggaṁ isippaveditaṁ

"*Vācānurakkhī*" means being guarded in speech. "*Manasā susaṁvuto*"—well-restrained in mind, in thought. "*Kāyena ca akusalaṁ na kayirā*"—doing no unwholesome deed with the body either. This means guarding all the three doors (of action). "*Ete tayo kammapathe visodhaye*"—"Purify all these three pathways of action (*kamma*). Because of these three doors, various actions (*kamma*) arise. Purify those pathways of action." By purifying them in this manner, "*ārādhaye maggaṁ isippaveditaṁ*"—"One accomplishes the path proclaimed and taught by the supreme sages, the Buddhas and others; one conducts oneself according to that path." This is the instruction.

Now, first, let us look at the themes we can extract as instructions for ourselves from the story related to this verse. We see from that story how two monks who were living in harmony, combining lying and slandering, with the painful desire of *adinnādāna* (taking what is not given) to acquire what did not belong to them, and adopting such a course of speech and action, consequently ended up in that terrible state.

Therefore, let us look especially at the "pig-mouthed *preta*" (*sūkara-preta*) mentioned in this current story—it is called *sūkara-preta* because of its pig-like mouth. Today, there is a great interest in this story of the *sūkara-preta* and about the "unseen world" among many people. A certain interest in these ghost existences (*bhūta-ātma*) and *preta* existences has arisen in this era. What we see from this present event is that there are indeed those with eyes that can see this unseen world. The Great Arahant Moggallāna saw it with his divine eye (*dibba-cakkhu*). However, since it was not visible to Venerable Lakkhaṇa, Moggallāna remained silent without mentioning it, thinking that Venerable Lakkhaṇa might accumulate unwholesome karma (*akusala*) by doubting or speaking against it. Likewise, the Buddha too, though he had seen it, did not declare it until he had a witness. Therefore, the eye that sees this unseen world is the divine eye (*dibba-cakkhu*). It has the power to see not only ghost existences and *preta* worlds, but also other worlds—hell (*niraya*), the *asura* world, and even the deva worlds and brahma worlds.

Thus, we must contemplate that there is such evidence here. The Dhamma mentions three kinds of eyes: the physical eye (*maṁsa-cakkhu*), the divine eye (*dibba-cakkhu*), and the wisdom eye (*paññā-cakkhu*). In Sinhala, we can call them *mamsa*, *divya*, and *paññasa*. *Paññasa* means the eye of wisdom (*paññā-cakkhu*). These three types of eyes are mentioned. Here, it is the divine eye (*dibba-cakkhu*) that is being spoken of. When the Buddha declared here, "My disciples live with eyes," he said so with this divine eye in mind. Now, in this day and age, some people—perhaps some skeptical relatives—might say, "We do not get to see such beings. There is no such thing." It is mentioned in the Dhamma that for those who cannot develop the divine eye to say there is no divine eye is just like blind people saying there is no sun, moon, or stars.

On the other hand, since there is an interest in this unseen world as mentioned, we can also say something about it. Today, many people—especially Western psychologists—using various terms like "hyper-mental" or "extrasensory"—using beautiful words—try to demonstrate various things about these three-fold worlds through certain experiments. This is like children's play. For those parapsychological investigations, they mostly employ hypnotism, mesmerism, and other such techniques. Through these, they attempt to uncover certain things about these three-fold worlds. However, according to the Dhamma, in the proper way—since many might doubt those methods—to realize it for oneself, that very divine eye (*dibba-cakkhu*) is necessary. It is by cultivating virtue (*sīla*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*), or specifically by attaining the meditative absorptions (*jhāna-samāpatti*) and generating that special power within the mind called direct knowledge (*abhiññā*), that one can bring forth the divine eye based on this physical eye. Then, those who possess that

divine eye see such worlds. It is with the help of that eye that the Buddha, as well as the Great Arahant Moggallāna, on many occasions demonstrated how beings in the world reach various states in accordance with their actions (*kamma*).

Now, if we contemplate a little further on this *preta* existence—that a body usually arises in exact accordance with one's karma—here too, when we think of that monk, he has a large body fitting the greatness he aspired to. Also, because of the impure words he used, his head was like that of a pig. Furthermore, the cunning trap he set to acquire that monastery is that pig's tail in his mouth. Also, worms were oozing from his body. Such was his state. It is mentioned that as a result of using harsh words to split and estrange people, one receives such hungry ghost existences (*preta-ātma*) with highly bizarre forms.

Not only that. There are many other parallel discourses (*sutta*) mentioned in the division of the Dhamma called the *Lakkhaṇa Saṃyutta*. Written in the form of dialogues between the Great Arahant Moggallāna and Venerable Lakkhaṇa—or rather, regarding the instruction given to those who ordained as disciples—many other matters are presented in the Dhamma. If we were to mention several of those terrifying *preta* forms—on every occasion those *preta* forms were seen, on every such occasion, as mentioned before, it was in the presence of the Buddha that the Great Arahant Moggallāna revealed the details. On those occasions, the Buddha also briefly pointed out the past history of each *preta*. There is a whole series of such discourses. Since they are similar, we shall mention them. On one occasion, it is mentioned that he saw a skeleton flying through the air. A skeleton was traveling through the air. Hawks, vultures, and crows were attacking and pecking between the ribs of that skeleton from time to time. That skeleton was flying through the air uttering wails. That form was of a cattle-butcher—one who slaughtered cattle—who lived in that very city of Rājagaha. Next, likewise, a piece of meat was flying through the air. Vultures were pecking at that piece of meat in the same manner. The piece of meat was screaming—a form in the shape of a piece of meat is described there. A *preta* existence with such a form. The karma for that is shown as a bird-hunter who lived in that very city of Rājagaha. Next, a human form without skin is mentioned. It too was flying through the air. Animals were pecking at it in the same manner. There, a sheep-hunter is indicated. Next, another *preta* existence is described, seen by the Great Arahant Moggallāna, with hairs like swords. Those swords, jumping up and down, fell back onto the body and cut it. That is shown as a pig-hunter. A pig-hunter who lived in that very city of Rājagaha received that state due to his karma. Next, another state of existence is shown: a *preta* is flying without a head. A headless *preta* form. Its eyes and mouth were located on its chest. Animals were pecking at it in the same manner. It was flying while uttering wails. In that case, the Buddha explains: this was a robber-executioner

who lived in that very city of Rājagaha. An executioner. What we call a hangman today. A man who kills captured thieves by cutting off their heads. The Buddha mentions this with his name, "Hārika the robber-executioner." Next, another such is shown. Another *preta* is immersed up to his head in a pit of feces. That person was one who committed adultery (*paradāra-sevana*). Next, on another occasion, the Great Arahant Moggallāna saw a skinless woman flying through the air—not by the force of wind. That too was a *preta* existence. Animals were pecking her in the same manner. She was a woman who committed adultery (*parapuruṣa-sevana*).

There is a large number of such existences. Next, what is even more important to remember in this day and age is that the Great Arahant Moggallāna saw a monk-form flying through the air—not by the force of wind. All the robes (double-layered robes) of that monk-form were on fire. The waistband was on fire. The bowl was on fire. It was flying through the air while burning. That was a sinful monk (*pāpa-bhikkhu*) from the time of Kassapa Buddha. Likewise, a sinful nun (*pāpa-bhikkhunī*), a sinful novice monk (*pāpa-sāmaṇera*), and a novice nun (*sāmaṇerī*) were flying through the air, burning in flames. So, these are things we must keep in mind.

We think of this as a great suffering. In almost every case, the Buddha points out that having first paid the major portion of this sinful karma (*pāpa-kamma*) in hell—having boiled in hell, having boiled in the great Avīci hell—they have received these *preta* existences as the residual portion of that bad karma. Thus, there are many instances in the discourses where the Buddha points out the results of karma (*kamma-vipāka*).

Based on this, even without being told anew, these devotees can understand the point we mentioned—how to bring about a new era. Now, let us also direct our minds to that verse. If we take the words of this verse in more detail: "**Vācānurakkhī**"—"one should guard one's speech." Generally, these devotees have heard of the ten unwholesome courses of action (*dasa-akusala*). They are the three bodily offenses: killing (*prāṇātipāta*), taking what is not given (*adinnādāna*), and sexual misconduct (*kāmesu-micchācāra*). Next, by speech: lying (*musāvāda*), slandering (*pisuṇāvācā*), harsh speech (*pharusiṇāvācā*), and frivolous talk (*samphappalāpa*). Now, in the *Ājīva-Atṭhamaka-Sīla* (Eight Precepts with Pure Livelihood as the Eighth) observed today, these are described as offenses committed by speech. The offenses committed by the mind are described as *abhidhyā*—which is covetousness or intense greed—*abhidhyā* is the intense greed to possess what belongs to others. Next, *vyāpāda*, which is hatred or ill-will. Next, "**micchā-diṭṭhi**", wrong view. These are the unwholesome deeds (*akusala*) committed by the mind, by

thought. Here, it says "**vācānurakkhī**"—here, speech has been given the primary place. This is because the unwholesome deed in this story is regarding speech. "**Vācānurakkhī manasā susaṁvuto**"—being well-restrained in mind means abstaining from those offenses committed by the mind. "**Kāyena ca akusalaṁ na kayirā**" means abstaining from those three offenses committed by the body. So, guarding these three doors is what should be done by anyone born in this human world who expects progress. As stated in the **Parābhava Sutta**, "One who loves the Dhamma prospers, one who hates the Dhamma declines" (**Dhammakāmo bhavaṁ hoti, dhammadesī parābhavo**). A person who loves the Dhamma is indeed the one who succeeds in the world. The person who hates the Dhamma meets with decline, which is destruction; he falls into ruin.

In the world today, however, people often argue for the opposite. Some say there is "no place" (no standing/prosperity) for a person who lives according to the Dhamma. What they call "place" or standing belongs to those who turn their backs on the Dhamma and live according to wrong livelihood (**micchā-ājīva**), employing various other tricks and legal loopholes. By whatever legal loophole one makes another's property one's own, that very loophole can come back to one's own mouth—directly to one's own mouth. There is such a dangerous situation. Then, what is the "standing" that those people have? According to the Buddha's words, based on the matters discussed, one can understand. It is hell, the animal realm, the **preta** world, and the **asura** realm. That is where it is. Therefore, for a person who seeks "such a place" (the secure path), they can shape their philosophy of life according to such a practice (**paṭipadā**).

So, based on this, we can understand: to live in such a way that we do not fall into those terrible states from this highly rare human existence (**manussa-atta-bhāva**) we have obtained, we must pay close attention to what the Buddha and other noble ones have taught regarding this mind, body, and speech.

Vācānurakkhī means one must engage in guarding one's speech. Sometimes, without even realizing it, a lie slips out, or slander, or harsh speech. Next, various other frivolous words. Therefore, one must develop a guard over speech. There must be restraint over the mind. Otherwise, without even realizing it, one adopts wrong views—due to associating with bad friends, one adopts wrong views. Or else, one generates thoughts of hatred. Or else, one generates intense greed. Now, in the monk mentioned here, there was **abhidhyā**—the intense greed, the corrupt greed to make what belongs to others one's own. Slander, lying, and then theft—all of these were present in that monk's course of action. The consequences of these are shown in that story.

Therefore, if we always practice this guard in our day-to-day lives, the Buddha has shown its result in this world—these devotees may have heard of it—if a lay

devotee lives a highly virtuous life, he receives a valuable happiness that others do not get. This is called "the happiness of blamelessness" (*anavajja-sukha*). From the feeling that "I have done no wrong," a person experiences great relief. The opposite of that is regret. Now, in the Dhamma too, the Buddha shows in one discourse the difference between the fool (*bāla*) and the wise (*paṇḍita*). The monk in this story might have thought that because he was a Dhamma-preaching monk and those other monks behaved in a very simple/weak manner, "I am the wise one." That so-called wisdom of his resulted in that very consequence. That is how the ordinary world thinks. If someone lives humbly according to the Dhamma, they are considered a fool. In this day and age, wisdom is recognized by the letters at the end of one's name, or else by the prefix before it. That is not how the Buddha showed the difference between the fool and the wise.

The fool is described as follows: "*dubbhita-cintī, dubbhāsita-bhāsī, dukkata-kammakārī*"—if someone thinks bad thoughts, speaks bad words, and takes bad courses of action, performs bad deeds, that person indeed is the fool. Next, the wise person is described as: "*suciñcita-cintī, subhāsita-bhāsī, sukata-kammakārī*"—if someone thinks good thoughts, speaks good words, and performs good deeds, that person indeed is the wise one. Showing the difference between these two, the Buddha demonstrates on that occasion how the fool, due to that foolishness—no matter how much he stands out in the world—suffers internal pain and regret. That is why the Dhamma describes four kinds of fear that a person who leads a wrong life must experience: the fear of self-reproach (*attānuvāda-bhaya*), the fear of others' reproach (*parānuvāda-bhaya*), the fear of punishment (*daṇḍa-bhaya*), and the fear of an unhappy destination (*duggati-bhaya*). One's own mind blames oneself. One has to hear the blame of others—the blame of wise people, not of just anyone. Next, one has to undergo punishment according to the laws of the land. Even if one escapes all of those, in the end, one goes to a bad destination (*duggati*).

Here, the Buddha explains further that very "fear of self-reproach" (*attānuvāda-bhaya*), where one's own mind blames oneself. He shows it as occurring on three occasions. Now, when a fool who has committed those wrongs such as killing, taking what is not given, and sexual misconduct, walks through the village, or through the town, or sits in an assembly, or stands at a crossroads, he hears others talking about those very sinful deeds (*pāpa-kamma*). It may not be about this person. But when they speak of killing, of theft, or of wrong deeds, that person's mind whispers from within, "I too have done such things, haven't I?" and his mind blames him. Those thoughts come to his mind. So, he feels regret: "I too have done these harsh things that they speak of." That is the first occasion. The second occasion is shown: this person receives punishment, or hears about it—as described in those days—a king captures those who committed such wrongs

and punishes them. Seeing this, or hearing about it, this person also experiences a shock in his heart: "Alas! I too have done these things, haven't I? If I am caught by the king's men, I too will have to suffer such torture." Thus, he feels regret in his mind, suffers, and repents. Next, this very regret is shown in the story—this person is either sitting on a chair, or lying on a bed, or lying on the ground. While remaining in this way, there comes to his mind the shadow, the image, of his past karma. The Buddha has given a simile to show this: just as in the evening, the shadow of a mountain stretches out gradually—just as that shadow hangs over the mountain, in the same way, the shadow, the image of the sinful karma he committed in the past, hangs over and overwhelms the mind of that fool, of that foolish person.

Some people, based on this simile, think that sinful karma is something that floats around in the sky, and that this is a simile for seeing that. That is not what is being said here. These devotees know that when describing wholesome (*kusala*) and unwholesome (*akusala*) qualities (*dhamma*), the simile of the shadow is given in the Dhamma. Likewise, what is spoken of here is this shadow. This shadow is something that brings sorrow to oneself, not something that brings joy. It is for one's regret. When we say "evening time," we know that as the sun goes down, that shadow lengthens. In the same way, the past sinful deeds affect the mind of this person. These must be experienced in this world—within this very life. It is said that from the very moment a sinful deed is committed, these results (*vipāka*) flow in. If "result" (*vipāka*) means a ripening, this is not something that ripens all of a sudden. It is not something that plunges one into hell all of a sudden after death. It "brews" (ripens) within the mind. It ripens within the mind in the manner described, in the form of regrets. Having ripened and ripened in this way, some people—as we often hear—suffer at the moment of death. We often hear of this in this day and age as well, not only in the Buddha's time.

These devotees must have heard of many such striking events from the Buddha's time. The pig-killer named Cunda lived right behind the Veluvana Monastery. He was highly skilled. What is done today with state aid—Cunda the pig-killer did that very work alone. Catching pigs, killing them, he carried on that livelihood. But at the moment of death, running here and there like a pig, uttering loud wails, and experiencing a mountain of great suffering, he was born in the Avīci hell. Similarly, we get to hear of other such events in the future. We might hear even more of them in the future as our economy develops—through the aforementioned wrong livelihood (*micchā-ājīva*). Therefore, it is not very necessary to give textual evidence for them. A time will come in the future when they can be seen in daily life. The consequences of spending life as human *pretas*—as human *yakṣas*—will be demonstrated in this very world. That is

highly important. Now, then, there will be plenty of work for those paranormal researchers, the Western scientists, to come, conduct research, and obtain degrees. But many who follow them make this a form of intellectualism, always "studying" these, writing books, and obtaining degrees, instead of learning the lesson from these and being eager to adjust their own lives—their philosophy of life. It is not for such a purpose that we showed these examples. It is not for these devotees to write books and get degrees, but to adjust their own lives and make that aforementioned deathless century—the new year—truly a new dawn, a new era.

Therefore, we must contemplate—in this world—whether we will become a fool or a wise person as shown by the Buddha. According to the Buddha's words, to become a wise person, one does not need to pass any examinations. Nowadays, the very word "wise" (*paṇḍita*) has a meaning associated with learning. But the Buddha gives a different meaning to it. Because wisdom means far-sightedness. If a course of action is short-sighted, no matter how many clever tricks one has, that person is not a wise person. Thinking and contemplating on this, it becomes clear. The Buddha—who is called the Knower of the Worlds (*lokavidū*)—is the supreme individual who knew everything that should be known about this world. The Buddha does not need clever tricks. Within that aforementioned quality of the Tathāgata lies the marvelous nature of the Buddha.

Thus, the Buddha, having known with his Buddha-knowledge, has shown in this very simple manner how one becomes a wise person in the world, and how one becomes a fool—along with its dangers (*ādīnava*) and benefits (*ānisaṃsa*). Therefore, we must contemplate: to adjust our lives, there is not much to do. These three doors we have—these three doors are open to society, to the external society. Thus, we must properly open and close these three doors. Guarding the three doors means: let us say a state of bias or greed (*agati*) came to us. At that moment, if a neighbor's bunch of bananas is nearby, or hanging into our garden, or if there is some property that no one is watching, with no owner to be seen, then we take it with a thieving mind. Next, regarding food—if it is tasty food, we kill an animal. In this way, our mind tells us to do various things. If we open the door in that direction according to those thoughts, harm is done to others.

Now, it is shown in the Dhamma, in the analysis of wholesome (*kusala*) and unwholesome (*akusala*) states—if we actually contemplate on the word "*kusala*"—nowadays, "*kusalatā*" means "skill/ability." If *kusalatā* is skill, then *kusala* actually means being skilled. It is not the analysis of skill and lack of skill done in this day and age that the Buddha has shown; who is the truly skilled one? What is recognized as true *kusala* is non-greed (*alobha*), non-hatred (*adosa*), and non-delusion (*amoha*). Let us first speak of the

unwholesome (*akusala*). What are shown as the roots of the unwholesome are greed (*lobha*), hatred (*dosa*), and delusion (*moha*)—the three roots of defilement (*kilesa-mūla*) that have existed for a long time in the mental stream of beings. Those courses of action that spring from body, speech, and mind due to these three roots are what are shown as *akusala*, on the one hand—taking them as the roots. Next, those very thoughts that help to steer away from that greed, hatred, and delusion—generating such concepts of non-greed, non-hatred, and non-delusion, and the actions performed, words used, and thoughts thought in accordance with them—are what can be shown as *kusala*.

To put another way, this human being does not live only with humans. In terms of saṃsāric connection, we may regard past beings as our parents and children; looking at the relationships in this Dhamma, in this long saṃsāra, we have taken birth even in those animal existences. One's parents, having passed away, might sometimes be born as dogs or cats in one's own home. Therefore, when we contemplate in this manner, this entire vast universe is a society. It is towards that society that the three doors are open. Thus, if someone, overcome by those aforementioned unwholesome roots, commits those bodily wrongs such as killing, taking what is not given, and sexual misconduct, or uses those words such as lying, slander, harsh speech, and frivolous talk—regarding the door of speech—and regarding the mind, if one generates that intense, corrupt greed (*abhidhyā*) in the mind, generates hatred, and takes into the mind those wrong views called *micchā-diṭṭhi*, then that person falls into that aforementioned state of a fool. Especially, he will have to suffer their consequences at that very moment. Thus, one must contemplate. That is what is called *akusala*—being unskilled. What is that lack of skill? For what reason does the Buddha call it unskilled? This saṃsāric journey is an extremely dangerous journey. If one does not go carefully, one will get into trouble. One will fall into great abysses. That very abyss is described by those words: "*apāyaṃ duggatiṃ vinipātaṃ nirayaṃ upapajjati*" (he is reborn in the state of deprivation, the bad destination, the abyss, the hell).

"*Apāya*" means, when a vehicle is traveling, deviating from that road. Suppose a vehicle went off the road. Next, "*duggati*" means like traveling through a wasteland. Then, running along the flat wasteland for a while. "*Vinipāta*" means then falling down a cliff. "*Niraya*" means being shattered to pieces. Think of it in that way. This might be a simile not found in the books, but it is mentioned because it helps to direct the mind. These four words are used: "*apāyaṃ duggatiṃ vinipātaṃ nirayaṃ upapajjati*". These four words are used regarding a person who has committed sins. In that manner, he went off the road to the bad side. Next, going along that wasteland, in the end, he falls down the

cliff and is destroyed. In that way, he falls into the state of hell. Thus, living in such a way that this does not happen is skill, *kusala*. Similarly, just as avoiding going to those bad places like hell—that bad side—next, one draws close to Nibbāna. What is Nibbāna? Nowadays, we hear some people arguing: "If you do meritorious deeds (*puñña-dhamma*) and the like, saṃsāra increases. Therefore, those are not necessary." On the other hand, there comes an opinion that meditation is not necessary either. However, in whatever way it is said, what we have to understand here is that the skill shown by the Buddha is to escape from that path to hell and draw close to Nibbāna as quickly as possible. What is Nibbāna? Nibbāna is the peacefulness, the supreme peace, the coolness of freeing the mind from greed, hatred, and delusion. If greed, hatred, and delusion are a fire, it is a certain "coolness"—a cool state—that one generates in one's own mental stream by extinguishing that fire. It is an extremely subtle, peaceful happiness. That is what is called Nibbāna, supreme peace. It is not something hanging in another world, or floating in the sky in that manner. Often, even Buddhist thinkers who follow scientists have become accustomed to thinking of all of this as something separate from themselves. Now, these devotees might often see in books, when they speak of this karma, rebirth, and all of that, they speak of them as if they were not something belonging to oneself, but as things that should be known by conducting scientific research in this world. Whether they affect oneself or not is understood at the moment of death—even on the deathbed.

Therefore, if one does not put all this knowledge into use, it is useless. No matter how much knowledge one has, that person is a fool, a *bāla*. If one is a wise person, one must be, as mentioned, "*suciñcita-cintī, subhāsita-bhāsī, sukata-kammakārī*". Through one's thoughts, one's words, and one's course of action, one must be aligned with the Dhamma. Turning away from greed towards non-greed. Drawing close to non-greed means drawing close to Nibbāna. Drawing close to non-hatred means drawing close to Nibbāna. Drawing close to non-delusion means drawing close to Nibbāna. Because Nibbāna is described as the end of the journey of non-greed, non-hatred, and non-delusion. Now, if we think of this for a moment as a journey, everyone of these devotees has heard that the saṃsāric journey is made based on greed, hatred, and delusion. Let us think of a race—or even if we think of a journey—we go from one place to another. Then, abandoning those three saṃsāric targets of greed, hatred, and delusion present in the saṃsāric being—turning one's back on them—seeking that peace called Nibbāna, escaping from those three fires and going towards coolness is what is called non-greed, non-hatred, and non-delusion. Every thought that helps in that is a help to Nibbāna. Something that helps towards Nibbāna. Then, when performing acts of charity and merit, a certain number of wholesome feelings

arise in that person's mind. When giving alms, within that feeling of letting go, the mental factor of non-greed (*alobha-cetasika*) is present. Compassion is there. Faith is there. Next, there is a moment when the feeling of "I" and "mine" disappears—when parting with something belonging to oneself, when giving it into the hand of another. Then, why would that not be a help to Nibbāna? Those do help towards Nibbāna. It is those very things, accumulated in that manner, that in the end, at some moment, bring about the fruit in that mental stream—the fruit of Nibbāna. If one aspires to Nibbāna, they bring about the fruit of Nibbāna. In addition, by weakening the unwholesome deeds that lead to hell, those places born as results of the wholesome side—such as the deva worlds and brahma worlds—are the places of birth. Those too are visible to the aforementioned divine eye (*dibba-cakkhu*). It may not be possible to find out much more about them through paranormal research. What is mostly found—what those researchers might find even more of in the future—are examples regarding the aforementioned *preta* worlds and ghost worlds. This is because those who go to that side are the majority.

Be that as it may, this group of devotees must contemplate: if we are indeed making a beginning of a century in that manner, what is this century? When we contemplate the long lifespans during the times of Kassapa Buddha—and even before him, Kakusandha, Koṇāgama, and other Buddhas—to us, a single year is like the blink of an eye. Contemplate, devotees, on how time passes. When directing the mind to the moment we thought of as the beginning of a century—it feels like it was just yesterday. Yet, it is within this that the world makes a great deal of merrymaking. What happens in the meantime? Our lives are spent. Our lives are spent. What is meant by a valuable life? A body obtained during the time of a Buddha's appearance, which can be directed towards the Dhamma, which can practice according to the Dhamma, without any physical disability. Now, those who received those *preta* existences as mentioned before are the ones who, when they finally receive human existence, suffer the consequences by being born with various kinds of physical disabilities. If this group of devotees is free from such physical disabilities, and possesses the power of understanding to comprehend the Dhamma, then this lifetime becomes a valuable one. Short, but a valuable thing. One must think of it as a valuable thing like a gem. Why? Because there are still things to be done for oneself. This is a highly valuable opportunity to bring this saṃsāric journey to an end. Thus, what helps towards that is the accumulation of virtuous qualities (*guṇa-dhamma*).

Thus, the brief statement here about training and purifying this mind, body, and speech can be described in various ways. It can be described as giving (*dāna*), virtue (*sīla*), and meditation (*bhāvanā*). It belongs to the threefold mass of merit (*puñña-kkhandha*). Next, if we look at it in another way, as directly

helping Nibbāna: virtue (*sīla*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*). It is about virtue (*sīla*) that was spoken here especially. Virtue—next, it is through virtue that one develops concentration. Some think of virtue as something unnecessary. The Buddha has declared: if someone performs "heavy work" that requires strength, if someone does heavy work, they must do so standing on a firm ground. One cannot lift a heavy load while standing in a mud pit. These devotees know this. Can one lift a heavy sack of grain while standing in a mud pit? Then, one would also sink. That is why these devotees observe this five-fold virtue (*pañca-sīla*), the eight-fold virtue with pure livelihood (*ājīva-aṭṭhamaka-sīla*), the eight poya-day precepts, the ten precepts, etc. It is based on that virtue that one concentrates the mind. This is because it becomes difficult to concentrate the mind if those regrets—which were mentioned in the story of the fool and the wise—if those regrets flow into the mind. To prevent those regrets, one must first discipline the body and speech. That is what is called virtue (*sīla*). One might have committed many sins in saṃsāra—but today, at this moment, these devotees who have observed these precepts can think, "No matter how it is on other days, today, on this day, I stand upon the principles of this virtue." Then, standing upon those principles of virtue, with the help of that strength, one can calm the mind and attain concentration (*samādhi*).

Concentration (*samādhi*) means removing those hindrances (*nīvaraṇa-dhamma*) that obstruct the oneness of the mind—such as sensual thoughts, thoughts of hatred, sloth and torpor, restlessness and worry, and skeptical doubt—and placing the mind on a certain wholesome object. Having concentrated the mind in that manner, next, one directs that concentrated mind to comprehend the true state of affairs shown by the Buddhas—the nature of impermanence (*anicca*), suffering (*dukkha*), and non-self (*anattā*). It is insight meditation (*vipassanā*) that helps in that comprehension. As insight, this is something that must be seen within one's own mental stream. This is not something that can be obtained from books. This is not something that can be obtained by conducting "research" in that manner. That research must be conducted internally. This is called "the noble quest" (*ariya-pariyesana*). What the Buddha did was also that noble quest. Therefore, on this highly valuable day, these devotees too must make a determination to conduct that noble quest. The beginning of making such a determination is what was expressed here—to be as diligent as possible in guarding these three doors of mind, body, and speech. No matter what kind of problems arise in day-to-day life, no matter what kind of difficulties come, if one does not guard these three doors, the Buddha has shown what will happen to oneself. He has declared, "*Kammasakā kammadāyādā*" (beings are owners of their actions, heirs to their actions); what one carries with

oneself, what truly belongs to oneself, is the good or bad one has done. Next, that indeed is one's inheritance in saṃsāra.

Contemplating on that, then, on this valuable Poya day, these devotees listened to many matters of the Dhamma of the Buddhas, which are helpful to one's life, which help to create a well-adjusted philosophy of life, and which help to bring about a true dawn. Bearing in mind that Buddha who preached this—we said these few matters not as something preached by us, but in connection with the teaching of the Buddha—one must generate the strength of faith (*saddhā*) towards the Triple Gem, firmly determine upon one's permanent virtue (*nicca-sīla*)—whether the five precepts (*pañca-sīla*) or the eight precepts with pure livelihood (*ājīva-aṭṭhamaka-sīla*)—and additionally, as a way of utilizing it, turn towards meditation and make a strong determination to spend this year in that manner.

During all this time, having restrained mind, body, and speech, and having observed a certain virtue, you listened to the Dhamma in a manner that well develops faith (*saddhā*), energy (*vīriya*), mindfulness (*sati*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*). This mass of merit (*kusala-sambhāra*) accumulated through this, and the mass of merit we have accumulated through preaching the Dhamma—we must contemplate: no matter what obstacles there are to this Dispensation (*sāsana*), to weaken this speed of decline, there exists a certain protective assembly of devas of right view (*sammā-diṭṭhika-deva-maṇḍala*), including those Deva and Brahma kings who associated with the Buddhas, who protect the Dispensation. Whether these devotees have seen them or not—may they also rejoice in these merits! May they provide further protection to this Dispensation! Likewise, we must transfer these merits to our departed relatives. May our lives also be directed towards the state of Nibbāna through this path of virtue, concentration, and wisdom (*sīla-samādhi-paññā-magga*), and by realizing the paths and fruits (*magga-phala-paṭivedha*) of Stream-entry (*Sotāpatti*), Once-returning (*Sakadāgāmi*), Non-returning (*Anāgāmi*), and Arahantship (*Arahatta*), may we realize the supreme, noble, great deathless Nibbāna! Aspiring thus, you must now share these merits by reciting the verses.

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”